



"What?" Maarika asked. "What kind of riddle is that?"

"Six minutes," Dolaidh said. Out in the hall, Ranveig let out a roar of pain and anger.

"Ranveig?" Maarika said, turning away from the sphinx and yanking her headset down, mic in front of her mouth.

"Incorrect code," said the sphinx. "A man jumps off a bridge. What color is the bridge?"

"Dolaidh! We don't have time for this," Maarika shouted into mic. "We need to help Ranveig and get out of here."

"No!" Dolaidh responded, sounding angry. "We don't leave until the job is done. That's the deal. That's the oath we all swore to each other!"

"Not at the cost of our lives," Maarika said.

"A man jumps off a bridge. What color is the bridge?" the sphinx repeated.

"The same color as it was before he jumped off!" Tisket snapped at the sphinx.

The sphinx smiled. "Final code accepted." With that, the golden chimera backed away from the vault entrance, curling up in a ball in the far corner, eyes closing.

Maarika and Tisket bolted into the vault, pulling open filing cabinets and upturning lockboxes in search of the right one. After a few moments, a small white case spilled out of a lockbox. Maarika picked it up and read the tidy handwritten label: 1652 Massachusetts Bay Colony Oak Tree Shilling.

"We've got it," Maarika said.

"Then get out of there," Dolaidh said. "Get Ranveig and go. We'll be out front, waiting."

Before Maarika and Tisket could leave the vault, the white case began vibrating. Maarika looked over at Tisket in alarm. Tisket plucked the case from Maarika's hand and opened it. Inside, instead of the shilling Dolaidh sent them in after, Tisket found a slim phone, buzzing and lighting up with a call. She put the phone to her ear.

"What?" Tisket said into the phone.

"*Zdravstvuyte*," said Baron Sevastyan's voice. "Put the phone to your other ear. I wish your employer to hear me."

"I'm on the no call list," Tisket said, transferring the phone to her other ear.